

PART 4: THE ADVENTURE

BEGINNING THE ADVENTURE:

When the players first enter a wilderness campaign, the DM should say a few words about the general area. This will include a brief description of the base town, notable NPCs living in the area, a description of the local churches for the clerics, and perhaps some rumors about local points of interest.

Base Towns. In the wilderness, the players will start from a base town. Base towns provide a place where a party can buy equipment and hire men and retainers, where treasure can be sold (and perhaps magic items identified), and where clerical healing is available for a suitable “contribution” or service. Rumors that can lead to adventure can be gathered from inns or taverns, the various guilds, or even the local town guardsmen.

Organizing a Party

In the DUNGEONS & DRAGONS® Basic rules, players could journey directly to the dungeon without difficulty or danger. Now, however, players must make more choices before play begins. They must decide where to go and what supplies they will need. They will have to establish a marching order for overland travel and organize guard watches for the night.

Before journeying into the wilderness, the party should organize itself and plan the journey along the following lines:

1. **Deciding where to go:** Choosing the goal of the adventure.
2. **Deciding what supplies are needed:** Preparing the party for the journey to the objective.
3. **Equipping and outfitting the party:** Buying the equipment the party will need for the exploration of the objective.
4. **Establishing a marching order:** Setting the party up to face combat and surprise situations.

Below is an example of how a party organizes itself for an adventure:

EXAMPLE: Ulo Ironbeard (a dwarf), Kras Tree-Tall (a fighter), Theodorus the Wise (a magic-user), Nimble Deantha (a thief), and Rothgar the Mighty (a fighter) decide to go on a journey to the city of Specularum. They meet at a tavern to prepare.

There is no road that goes directly to Specularum, and none of the party has been there before. Theodorus tries to question some merchants, but finds their directions vague. Rothgar looks for a map showing the route, but without success. In the end, the party decides to hire a guide and two retainers. (As it turns out, the DM will allow only one retainer and the guide to be hired.)

The guide tells them the journey will take about three weeks and Theodorus the Wise is given the task of making a list of needed equipment. In addition to the equipment they already have, Theodorus writes down the following:

- 8 horses (4 for the party, 2 for retainer and guide, and 2 extras).
- 2 mules (one for Ulo Ironbeard, who refuses to ride a horse, and one to carry supplies).
- 7 saddles and bridles.
- 2 lances (for Kras and Rothgar).
- 1 pack saddle (for the pack mule).
- 12 flasks of oil.
- Rope (200’).
- Spell books (belonging to Theodorus).
- Blankets
- 21 weeks of standard rations (3 for each person).
- 21 waterskins (3 for each person).

The party knows supplies may not be found in the wild, so they have bought extras of some items (such as oil flasks). They agree to split up and buy their individual supplies, meeting at the tavern when all is purchased.

Having bought their equipment, the group rides through the city gate. As in a dungeon, the party arranges themselves in a marching order: Rothgar the Mighty ahead of the rest; Ulo Ironbeard, the retainer, Theodorus the Wise, and the guide in the second rank; and Nimble Deantha and Kras Tree-Tall in the rear. Further, they agree to let Rothgar do the talking when strangers are encountered, as he has the highest Charisma in the party. So organized, they leave the city on their way to Specularum.

Mapping

The DM should prepare a map of the campaign area ahead of time, noting general features such as the type of terrain, villages, rivers, etc. It has been found that paper with a hexagonal or square grid is most useful for making maps. Hexagonal-grid maps are the best because there are six spaces to go to that are an equal distance from the space started from; with a square grid there are only four (diagonals distort the distance). Thus, whenever the rules use “hexagon” in connection with maps, it simply means “a space on the map”. The scale on these maps is often 6 miles per hexagon.

Players will want to keep a permanent map of the areas they pass through. Usually players can map only the hexagon they are actually in, but this may vary with terrain (one can see farther on top of a mountain than in a valley).

Moving through a wilderness hexagon will give the players only a general idea of terrain features, as well as obvious signs of civilization — roads, cities, castles, farms, and the like. Players will not gain any specific knowledge of the inhabitants unless they spend extra time there.

Time, Scale and Movement:

Unlike dungeons, the basic measure of distances in the wilderness is yards instead of feet. In the wilderness it is easier to move great distances. There is more open terrain, the lighting is better and there are fewer uncertainties in general. To calculate how far a character may move in the wilderness in one day, convert the number of feet he or she may move in a turn to miles by dividing by 5. The result is then read as miles. A man who moves 90’ a turn in the dungeon will move 18 miles in a day ($90/5 = 18$).

The distance a character may move in a 10 minute turn is equal to the distance moved in the dungeon read as yards. Therefore, a man who moves 90’ a turn in the dungeon will move 90 yards (270’) in the wilderness. The distance moved in a combat round is also read as yards.

Missile and spell ranges are also read as yards in the wilderness. **IMPORTANT NOTE: THE AREA AFFECTED BY A SPELL IS NOT READ AS YARDS.** Thus, a **fire ball** spell cast in the wilderness would have a range of 240 yards, but still affect an area 40 feet in diameter.

Movement in the wilderness is normally calculated in terms of number of days travelling, and are referred to as such. Each day a character may move so many miles and this movement will equal 1 day. If the characters have an encounter, the time scale is changed to rounds. Ten minute turns are seldom used in wilderness play.